The October 10 board meeting was far quieter than anticipated, following the Centre's directive to resolve internal disputes amicably and behind closed doors. In a notable departure from routine, the venue shifted from the Trusts' Cuffe Parade headquarters to the Taj Mahal Hotel in Colaba—seen as an effort to escape unnecessary media attention.

Chairman Noel Tata and trustees Venu Srinivasan (chairman emeritus, TVS Motor Company), Mehli Mistry (director, M. Pallonji Group, and cousin of the late Cyrus Mistry, former Tata Group chairman) and Pramit Jhaveri (former Citibank CEO) attended in person. Vijay Singh, former defence secretary and long-time Tata loyalist, and Jehangir H.C. Jehangir, chairman of Jehangir Hospital, Pune, joined virtually. Darius Khambata, another trustee and senior lawyer, was reportedly absent. There was little on the agenda beyond routine matters—the board reviewed and cleared philanthropic projects worth Rs 1,100 crore.

THE RISE OF THE FACTIONS

However, the calm at that meeting belied the turbulence of the preceding days. The 133-year-old Tata Trusts—which usually operates away from the public eye, quietly steering the Tata Group from behind the scenes—had witnessed a string of unprecedented developments barely a year after chairman emeritus Ratan Tata's passing in October 2024. Tensions between two factions of trustees had been simmering for months: one led by Noel, with Srinivasan and Vijay Singh in his corner, and the other by Mistry, backed by Jhaveri, Jehangir and Khambata. The latest flashpoint concerned the reappointment of Singh, 77, also vice-chairman of the Trusts' board, to the board of Tata Sons. According to the Tata Sons Articles of Association (AoA), Tata Trusts has the right to nominate one-third of the company's directors—a coveted privilege, since such nominees hold veto power on key decisions under Article 121.

While Noel and Srinivasan are already nominee directors on the Tata Sons board (alongside Chandrasekaran, Harish Manwani, Anita M. George and Saurabh Agrawal), the Noel faction's effort to reappoint Vijay Singh was blocked by the rival camp in a September 11 meeting, citing Singh's advanced age. Singh has reportedly since resigned from the Tata Sons board.

Tata Sons directors are required to retire at 65, although non-executive directors may continue until 70. This rule was relaxed for Ratan Tata, who stepped down at 75 in 2012, and again for Chandrasekaran, whose second term as chairman, originally set to end in 2027 when he turns 65, has been extended by five years to ensure "continuity". Following Ratan Tata's death last year, Tata Trusts decided that its nominees on the Tata Sons board who cross 75 would need to seek reappointment annually. Having successfully blocked Singh's reappointment, the rival faction reportedly sought to place Mehli Mistry in his stead—a move opposed by the Noel faction, further deepening the boardroom divide.

The infighting over board positions has left a bitter taste among the trustees. Both factions claim to carry

INSIDE TATA TRUSTS

The Philanthropic Powerhouse Behind The Tata Empire



Mehli Mistry

Vijay Singh



ORIGINS: Traced to 1892 with the creation of the JN Tata Endowment for Higher Education by Jamsetji Tata

HOLDINGS: Control a 66% stake in Tata Sons, the holding company of the Rs 16 lakh crore Tata Group

CORE ENTITIES: The two principal trusts are the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust and the Sir Ratan Tata Trust. Together, they disbursed around Rs 700 crore in grants during FY24

ALLIED TRUSTS: Lady Tata Memorial Trust, JRD Tata Trust, Jamsetji Tata Trust, Tata Social Welfare Trust, Tata Education Trust, RD Tata Trust, JRD and Thelma J. Tata Trust, Sarvajanik Seva Trust etc.

LEADERSHIP: Noel Tata serves as chairman, other trustees are Venu Srinivasan, Vijay Singh, Jimmy N. Tata, Jehangir H.C. Jehangir, Mehli Mistry, Darius Khambata (common to both key trusts) and Pramit Jhaveri (Sir Dorabji only)

KEY DIVIDE: Tensions between the Noel Tata and Mehli Mistry factions over reappointment of Vijay Singh to the Tata Sons board; differences among trustees over the public listing of Tata Sons